as the China–Sikkim border, since China had not explicitly recognized Sikkim as a part of India. Presuming Chinese silence to be tantamount to acquiescence, if not acceptance, had cost India dearly in the 1950s.

The Indian side, therefore, pressed upon the Chinese side to include an explicit geographical reference to confirm that the passes through which the border trade would be conducted were located on the India–China border. The Indian side also pressed for a clear iteration from China to describing the proposed trade marts on either side, at Changgu and Renqinggang, as 'Changgu, Sikkim, India' and 'Renqinggang, Tibet Autonomous Region, People's Republic of China'. [22] This might appear as semantics, but this was not a mistake to be made when negotiating with the Chinese. The Chinese officials resisted all efforts to add the country names. This strengthened the feeling on the Indian side that the Chinese were mendacious. However, Prime Minister Vajpayee was preparing to leave for his first official visit to China. The Chinese recognized that political pressure was mounting on Indian officials to conclude an agreed text before Vajpayee's first visit to China as Prime Minister in June 2003. China was hoping that this pressure would force India to compromise on its 'all-or-nothing' approach.

The Chinese pressure tactic worked. The Chinese strung the Indian side along until the border trade agreement was nearly ready and the visit of the Indian Prime Minister was imminent, before they reverted to their old talk of recognition of Sikkim being a 'gradual process'. At this point, the political dispensation in India might have felt the need for a major foreign policy achievement before the 2004 general election. The desire to sound the trumpets seemed to be so strong that the Government of India might not have been able to resist the temptation to sign the trade agreement and claim that they had